and implement his conclusions, which could still be valid. All the militants of the Master Cell and Al-Fatah were beneficiaries of a political system that sought rapprochement, rather than the perpetual exile or neutralisation of those who transgressed its limits. It is obvious that rapprochement failed miserably in the valley and perhaps it failed because the doorkeepers to the 'twilight zone' wanted to keep the doors open for the continuing cross-fertilisation of newer 'transients' and never really wanted the rapprochement to succeed?

The Punjab Police had ruled out sabotage of Nath's aircraft, but civil aviation officials are still sceptical about the police's explanation.[9] Both the pilots of the Beechcraft were highly-trained and experienced, and the plane had so far logged zero-defect flights. The Punjab Government's inquiry to probe the cause of the crash was not conclusive nor was any forensic investigation undertaken. Nath became Punjab's Governor in August 1991 when it was the most sought-after seat in the country. The state was under President's rule and terrorism was at its worst. By putting to use his stints as a troubleshooter in Mizoram and Kashmir and as an advisor to Arjun Singh when he was Punjab Governor, Nath succeeded where his predecessors had failed.

Even though a unified command had been set up in 1993 by the Governor, General Krishna Rao, an ex-Indian Army Chief, there was little unity in the actions of several elements that were brought together to counter the Pakistan sponsored insurgency. The unified command included the state's chief secretary, the home secretary, the DG of police, the IGs of the BSF, CRPF and Jammu and Kashmir Police, and representatives of the Indian Army's Srinagar-based XV Corps. But the conflicting approach of these elements became only too evident in the handling and the subsequent fallout of the siege, following the presence of armed militants, in two of Kashmir's important places of worship.

The Hazratbal crisis in late 1993, first put the administration in a spot. Hazratbal is a mosque on the outskirts of Srinagar, on the banks of the Dal Lake, in which the *Moi-e-Muqqadas*—a hair of the Holy Prophet—is preserved as a sacred relic. For most people in the valley, this was their